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‘Am I just gonna miss my big day?’

Teens, parents say designer failed to fulfill paid-for prom dresses

By Audrey Pachuta and Caroline Kubzansky
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Beverly Fisher spent more than a year envisioning her daughter wearing the senior prom dress of their dreams.

For her, it was a goal worthy of hourlong drives from suburban Dolton to Humboldt Park, where she said a designer recommended by her sister-in-law promised to combine the details of three existing dresses into one black, crystal-lized masterpiece.

Appointment after appointment, deposit after deposit, Fisher said she paid Makeda Evans of Makeda E. Designs \$2,200 over the last 14 months.

Now, after the designer repeatedly pushed back the pickup date and then stopped responding altogether, Fisher’s daughter, Emon’ee, will attend senior prom Friday without the dress she paid for.

“She made me feel like I failed my daughter,” Fisher said, detailing moments she dissolved into tears of frustration. “This is one moment they can’t get back.”

Fisher’s experience at Makeda E. Designs is hardly an anomaly.

Scores of people gathered outside Evans’ Pulaski Road design shop Wednesday evening after being told their dresses and suits would be complete, according to a police report obtained by the Tribune.

Each of them said they had already paid for their outfits in full, according to the report. Some of them have proms as soon as this weekend to attend.

When they arrived, witnesses said the doors were locked and Evans stopped answering her phone.

“She obviously wasn’t at the shop,” said Chiquita Hodges, another mother who said her

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President Donald Trump walks with Chinese President Xi Jinping on Thursday in Beijing. **MARK SCHIEFELBEIN/AP**

Xi warns of clash if Taiwan mishandled

Chinese leader admonishes Trump, underscoring how far apart they are on thorny issues

By Will Weissert and Aamer Madhani
ASSOCIATED PRESS

BEIJING — China’s Xi Jinping warned President Donald Trump on Thursday that their two countries could clash over Taiwan if the issue is not handled properly, an unusually harsh admonition that stood in contrast to the American leader’s praise for his counterpart.

The exchange at a highly anticipated summit in Beijing underscored just how far apart Trump and Xi still are on thorny issues, including the war in Iran, trade

disputes and Washington’s relations with Taiwan, an island that is self-ruled but which China claims as part of its territory.

It also suggested that Trump’s three-day visit to China is likely to be longer on pageantry and symbolism than substantive political or economic breakthroughs.

The pair met for about two hours behind closed doors at the Great Hall of the People after an elaborate welcome ceremony featuring booming cannons, a band playing “The Star-Spangled Banner” and China’s national anthem, and hundreds of school-

children jumping and waving flowers and American and Chinese flags.

According to a post on X by Chinese Foreign Ministry spokesperson Mao Ning, Xi told Trump that “the Taiwan question is the most important issue in China-U.S. relations.”

“If it is handled properly, the bilateral relationship will enjoy overall stability. Otherwise, the two countries will have clashes and even conflicts, putting the entire relationship in great jeopardy,” she wrote.

That comment followed a brief

public exchange before the meeting began in which Trump told Xi: “You’re a great leader. Sometimes people don’t like me saying it, but I say it anyway, because it’s true.”

“It’s an honor to be your friend,” Trump said before promising that the U.S.-China relationship “is going to be better than ever before.”

Trump later told Fox News’ Sean Hannity in an interview that Xi said during their conversations that he “would like to be of help” in negotiating an end to the Iran

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Mayor Brandon Johnson talks in his office at Chicago City Hall on Thursday. He argued CPS should be spending more, not less. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Johnson decries further CPS cuts

Black enrollment at stake, mayor says in interview at 3-year mark in office

By Alice Yin and Jake Sheridan
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Mayor Brandon Johnson on Thursday condemned further cuts to Chicago Public Schools following the district’s latest proposal to address a yawning budget deficit by eliminating teaching staff, arguing the fate of Black enrollment is at stake.

During an interview with the Tribune ahead of his three-year mark in office, the mayor responded to questions on

planned cuts to teaching positions in the next school year by saying the nation’s fourth-largest school district needs to spend more, not less. Throughout the sit-down, Johnson also stuck to his talking points on Chicago needing more progressive taxation while continuing to refuse to say if he will run for a second term next year.

“You’re not going to be able to cut your way to success,” Johnson said. “Again, you have more white families in our public schools, but the

loss of population has been Black students. That’s where the attacks have been. That’s where the cuts have gone. And I don’t believe that that’s the policy that we should continue to move forward on.”

Yet Johnson showed no inclination to try to lean on CPS CEO Macquiline King, whom he appointed and who proposed the budget, or on the Chicago Board of Education, which he controls, to make changes to

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Fundraising heats up in races for city’s school board

For the first time, all 21 seats will be up for election in November

By Kate Armanini
CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Five months before elections, candidates for Chicago’s first fully elected school board have raised more than \$830,000, with board president hopeful Sendhil Revuluri accounting for nearly one-third of that total.

The Chicago Teachers Union and special interest groups that spent heavily on the 2024 board race have yet to make significant contributions. But many are mobilizing for what may well be the largest school board election in the country.

A Tribune analysis of more than three dozen active candidate committees found that just over \$550,000 had been raised as of the last filing period, March 31. That sum, first reported by Chalkbeat, includes loans and in-kind donations for staffing, food and event space.

Another \$280,000 has poured in over the past six weeks, according to state records, though that figure excludes donations less than \$1,000. Those smaller, unitemized contributions won’t be reported until the

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BRETT BEINER

Masterful first play in TimeLine’s new home

Shorn of the stars and gimmicks that undermined its Broadway premiere, Amy Herzong’s taut version of “An Enemy of the People” sits beautifully in TimeLine Theatre’s brand new complex. **Arts & Entertainment**

Clash over rescinded dinner invitation

The Union League Club of Chicago is facing a lawsuit from member Steven Goodwin after he was suspended for refusing to disinvite his date to an annual dinner. **Business**

Electric atmosphere ahead for City Series

The Cubs return to Chicago looking to regroup after a challenging trip, and the White Sox are playing some of their best baseball of the young season. **Sports**

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